

“The key to successful leadership today is influence, not authority.”

Ken Blanchard, US management and leadership author

Motivating staff

Defining achievable goals for each employee is the best way of getting across your expectations and motivating your staff. But take care to ensure that targets for individual staff members do not undermine collective working. Setting the wrong targets can result in employees competing with each other rather than cooperating and sharing information.

If you get to know your staff as individuals, it will make it easier for you to spot if something is wrong. Adopt a “walk-and-talk” strategy, regularly mixing with employees to find out how they are and whether they are coping. Let them know what is happening in the business, and remind them of their value in the workplace. Remember that if staff feel appreciated, they are more likely to perform well.

! BE AWARE

There is considerable legislation around discipline and dismissal. Make sure that your business has a policy that reflects this and that all staff are aware of it. If in doubt, engage the services of a legal professional. Be sure to:

- › **Gather** relevant evidence.
- › **Give** the employee an opportunity to improve.
- › **Be fair** and impartial.

Failing to follow the law is likely to result in a claim for unfair dismissal (see pp.212–215).

DISCUSSING PERFORMANCE PROBLEMS



If a member of staff is not performing as well as they should, act quickly to prevent the problem from escalating and affecting your business. Speak to the person informally to establish what can be done. If this does not work, then you will need a more formal meeting.

- › **Gather evidence** of any poor performance in advance. Let the person know why you are meeting.
- › **Be firm but fair**, making sure you focus on the problem and not on the personality of the individual.
- › **Be calm** and supportive; it is likely to be a difficult and possibly stressful experience for the employee.
- › **Explain the situation** as you see it, then invite the employee to respond.
- › **Work together** to agree on a performance improvement plan; this is better than imposing one.
- › **Put your agreement in writing** and set a date for a follow-up meeting.